

A large, stylized MLB logo serves as the background for the title. The logo is composed of two interlocking shapes: a grey one on the left and a pink one on the right, both with rounded corners. The letters 'M' and 'L' are integrated into the design, with the 'M' being grey and the 'L' being pink. The background of the entire page is white.

THE YOUTH MOVEMENT OF MAJOR LEAGUE BASEBALL

*A Scouting and Player-Development Analysis of 10 of MLB's Most
Exciting Young Hitters in 2026*

*By Justin Fuls
September 9, 2026*

PREFACE

Earlier this year, FanGraphs writer Ben Clemens posted an article titled “[Hitters Keep Getting Younger. Pitchers Stay the Same Age](#).” In this article, Clemens dives into the multi-decade trend of MLB players, specifically position players, continually getting younger and debuting earlier. The wide array of young talent making an immediate impact across MLB in 2026 stood out to me and made me want to understand what could be driving many early-career breakouts. My goal in this analysis was to examine the best young hitters from 2026 and see what qualities and adjustments could explain their breakouts.

I divided the players into two groups: established young hitters who made significant jumps in 2026 and rookie-eligible hitters in their first full Major League season. I also narrowed the scope of two pools of players by limiting the players to the following parameters: players younger than 25 with less than 2 years of service (with the one exception of Jordan Walker, who has 2 years and 44 days of service time, but was included because he spent portions of each of the last 2 years in MiLB). This would allow me to analyze players in the league who made considerable adjustments at the MLB level, as well as rookies who have had to adapt their offensive profiles more in-season after being exposed to MLB pitching. The service time cutoff would also allow me to remove players with a longer track record and focus on those with minimal MLB experience. This excluded players such as Bobby Witt, Gunnar Henderson, Julio Rodriguez, Corbin Carroll, Elly De La Cruz, Zach Neto, Riley Greene, and Michael Harris II.

I selected the group of 10 players from the OPS leaders among players under 25. From that list, I wanted to examine players I believe could sustain their breakout performances this year and rookies I feel strongly will grow into All-Star-caliber players. The 10 players in this analysis are:

Established Players

Pete Crow-Armstrong, *Chicago Cubs, OF*
Junior Caminero, *Tampa Bay Rays, 3B*
James Wood, *Washington Nationals, OF*
Jordan Walker, *St. Louis Cardinals, OF*
Jac Caglianone, *Kansas City Royals, DH*

Rookies

Sal Stewart, *Cincinnati Reds, 1B*
Kevin McGonigle, *Detroit Tigers, SS*
Carson Benge, *New York Mets, OF*
JJ Wetherholt, *St. Louis Cardinals, 2B*
Chase DeLauter, *Cleveland Guardians, OF*

The table of contents lets you jump to specific player reports. Each report looks at what went right in 2026, what changes were made to the player's game, how those changes could have contributed to better batted-ball data and on-field performance, and the player's baserunning and defensive profile to round out the analysis. I watched live game footage, consulted Baseball Savant's player profiles, and used FanGraphs' statistical profiles to enhance my analysis of each player's offensive adjustments. The end of the report will also draw conclusions from the changes made by the 10 players, looking at: 1) what adjustments players made; 2) what their

development tells us about MiLB and the amateur draft; 3) what organizations can learn when evaluating their own prospects; 4) how these trends in player breakouts could intersect with 2027 CBA negotiations.

Any mention of WAR refers to fWAR. Age and service time are based on the start of the 2026 season. Service time is listed in official MLB-style years.days format (y.ddd). All stats and metrics are accurate as of September 9, 2026.

This is my most in-depth report and best example of my scouting and analytics skills. This report is part of a larger effort to build a baseball scouting and analytics portfolio that demonstrates the value I can bring to scouting and baseball operations roles within MLB organizations.

I'm continuing to pursue opportunities in scouting, player development, baseball operations, and analytics, and I welcome feedback and am open to discussions on any of my work to foster connections.

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Pete Crow-Armstrong

24.0 years old

Service Time: 1.117

G	AVG/OBP/SLG	HR	RBI	SB	BsR	wRC+	DRS	fWAR
146	.281/.375/.574	41	97	36	6.5	158	15	9.9

A BREAKOUT BUILT ON IMPROVED SWING DECISIONS

Crow-Armstrong has taken his game to a whole new level, both offensively and defensively, and has shown a true ability to be an elite 5-tool player for years to come. Even though he was already an All-Star and WBC Team USA contributor in 2025 and 2026, the jump he has made has made him the NL MVP frontrunner, tracking for 10 to 11 fWAR. PCA has increased his batted-ball data and his approach to refine his game. PCA had a wOBA of .323 (.321 xwOBA) in 2025. This year, it jumped to .402 wOBA (.372 xwOBA), going from league-average to elite. PCA's K% has slightly increased, but his BB% has dramatically increased from 4.5% to 11.5%.

The MLB average sits at 8.9% in 2026 and was 8.4% in 2025, indicating an area of his game where PCA went from below-average to significantly above average. His ability to impact the game with approach and batted ball data has translated into more impact for the Cubs on the field as well, going from 5.4 wRAA to 45.3 in 2026. PCA's improved swing decisions have also translated into stronger batted-ball data. As mentioned, BB% is up 7% this year. By seeing better pitches and being more patient, there have been drastic changes in many of PCA's swing metrics: hard-hit %: 41.6% → 48.9%. Fast-swing %: 28.5% → 51.9%, bat speed 72.7 mph → 74.9 mph, blast-contact %: 14.7 % → 16.5%, blast swing%: 10.8% → 12.9%. Crow-Armstrong's swing itself has not changed from 2025, with his tilt, attack angle, and swing length all staying relatively the same. With no major bat path or pre-pitch setup changes to increase these metrics, PCA is more focused on getting his pitch, consistent with an overall swing % decrease from 59.5% to 49.1%, which is closer to league average. PCA is also hitting the ball further out in front of the plate, intercepting the ball 2.8 inches further in front of the plate than the Major League average, a possible indicator he is being more aggressive on hittable pitches. An interesting stat for PCA this year is that he has surpassed his total swings from last year, which could be another indicator that he is hunting pitches more frequently and accepting getting fooled occasionally, with whiff and chase rates sitting in the 36th and 23rd percentiles, respectively.

2025 TO 2026 MECHANICAL ADJUSTMENTS

2025



2026



Figure 1. Crow-Armstrong's 2025 and 2026 home-run swings on low fastballs

Looking at PCA's swing mechanics in 2025 compared to 2026, we see PCA has made strides to stay more upright during his swing, not collapsing his back leg, and focusing on not pulling off as much. Figure 1 shows HRs hit by PCA on hittable fastballs down in the zone. In

Figure 1, the bottom panel is his 2026 swing, and when comparing it vertically with 2025, we see that PCA was collapsing his backside, leaning out of his back-hip coil, and spinning off the pitch, leaving him off-balance. Not staying in his back leg and spinning off a pitch hurts PCA's power potential and also makes it harder for him to stay on time and make consistent hard contact, especially on offspeed pitches. In 2026, PCA refined his swing to sit back more on his back leg, staying more consistent and upright throughout. Figure 2 shows PCA at his foot plant and at contact. The white lines show where his front hip started at foot plant, while the red line shows where his front hip finished after rotating. PCA does a fantastic job rotating hard into his hip while keeping his front leg locked. At contact, PCA is providing a great transfer of power from his back hip to his barrel, all without leaking any power, unlike in 2025. PCA has made some other stance adjustments that have been well noted going into 2026, such as moving closer to the plate and quieting his hands. Moving closer to the plate could allow him to stay more upright and reach pitches on the outer half with the barrel rather than needing to flail at those pitches.



Figure 2. Crow-Armstrong at foot plant and contact, with front-hip rotation reference lines

Both swings in Figure 1 came on home runs. This is a good example of PCA's jump: in 2025 he was a great player, and now he is an MVP candidate. In 2025, he had a good swing but has put in the work to refine the inconsistencies and turn in one of the smoothest swings in the game.

ELITE DEFENDER GETS EVEN BETTER

With 14 DRS in 2025, already at 15 in 2026 and on track for more, and having surpassed both OAA and FRV, one of the premier center field defenders in baseball is getting better. PCA is a data darling, ranking in the 96th percentile for sprint speed, 89th for arm strength, 96th for arm value, and 100th for range and Fielding Run Value (FRV). The advanced metrics also show PCA

has an advanced burst (~100th percentile since 2024, with a 4.5-foot jump above average) to pair with an advanced arm that causes runners to advance 3% less than average.

The best advantage PCA has is moving laterally, with OAA showcasing 11 OAA moving both towards 3B and 1B, and only 2 OAA moving back. That could be because of the nature of Wrigley Field and trying to avoid running back towards the brick wall. PCA's advanced speed, burst, and jumps help him to get to balls in the gap more so than the average. PCA also tends to play a deeper center, meaning the OAA moving back being lower is not unexpected, especially considering the unfriendly wall at Wrigley. The Cubs could also be positioning PCA deeper in center to take advantage of PCA's sprint speed and jumps on shallow fly balls. PCA is getting better reads than anyone, and it is a major defensive advantage for the Cubs. Crow-Armstrong's defensive profile provides him a high floor, while his continuing growth surrounding his plate discipline and approach has raised his offensive ceiling.

Junior Caminero

22.7 years old

Service Time: 1.058

G	AVG/OBP/SLG	HR	RBI	SB	BsR	wRC+	DRS	WAR
144	.282/.368/.536	39	93	3	-2.6	148	0	4.9

ADJUSTING TO PITCHER GAME PLANS

Caminero has made a big jump after hitting 45 hrs in 2025. He is more of a prototypical slugger with advanced hit and power tools, with little defense or speed to add. At only 22, Caminero has a realistic path to becoming one of the premier power hitters of his generation. Caminero has changed his approach to increase his offensive production. His wOBA and xwOBA were .357/.346 in 2025, but have jumped to .383/.365 in 2026. He has shown the ability to reduce his K% year over year since his rookie year, going from 22.2% in 2023 to 18.4% in 2026, going from average discipline to above-average. His BB% has also increased in the span, up from 6.3% to 11.6%, again showing his growing plate discipline and approach. This year specifically, being more selective at the plate has decreased his swing% from 50.4% to 43.9%, below MLB average, all while increasing his contact%. This is the most impressive stat, as pitchers are pitching him extremely carefully, seeing 6.2% fewer pitches in the zone this year. He went from a 2025 zone% of 49% to 42.7% in 2026, and his first-pitch strike% fell from 59.9% to 53.7%. Caminero is being pitched to like the best hitters in the game, as pitchers are avoiding attacking him in the zone, and yet, his results have only improved. Caminero is showing an advanced feel for the game as pitchers adjust to his performance, not becoming too anxious or jumpy at the plate and trying to force good contact. Having this advanced discipline at 22, with a track record of tangible improvements in his approach, Caminero is showing advanced progression at such an age that he could be playing NCAA baseball.

STANCE AND PLATE POSITION CHANGES

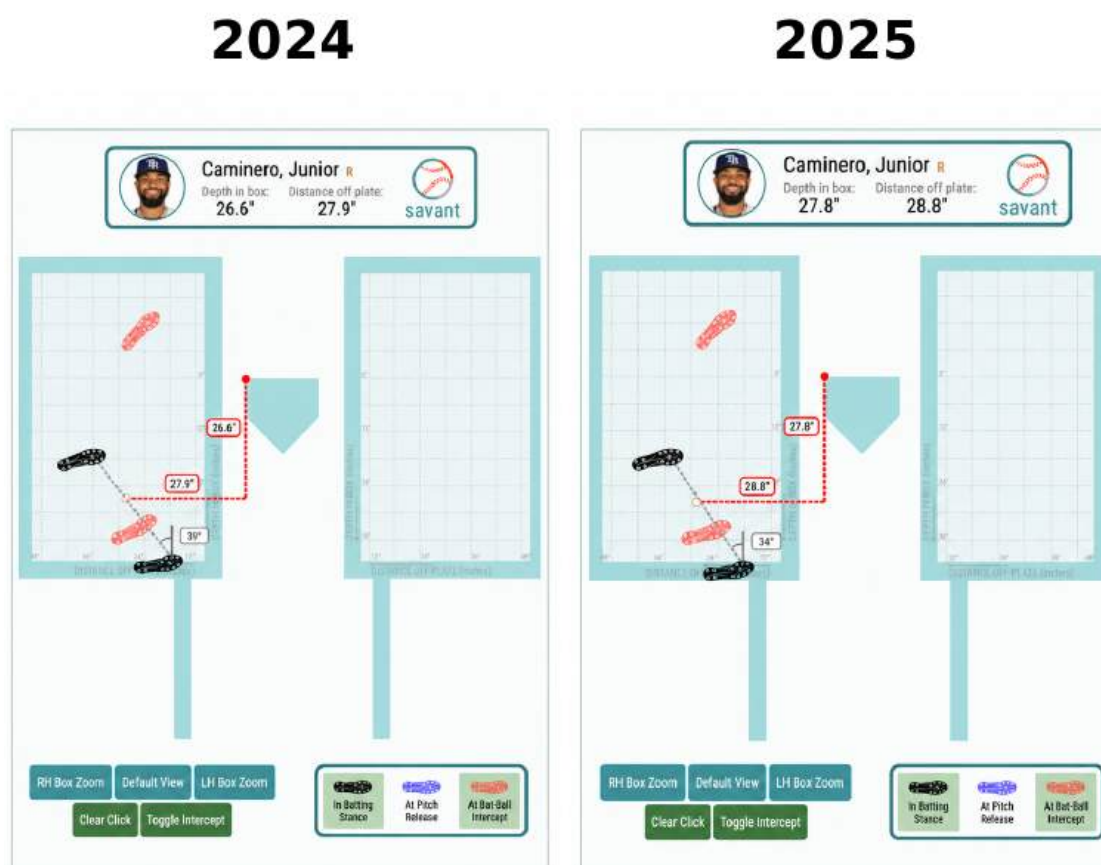


Figure 3. Caminero's batter's-box position and pre-pitch stance, 2024 vs. 2025

Caminero made more noticeable changes to his swing before the 2025 season, specifically to his setup in the box before delivery. In Figure 3, in 2024, Caminero showed an open stance, more so than average players, before coming closed and striding directly at the pitcher. On the right, in 2025, he was even significantly more open, 5 degrees more. Caminero also shifted slightly further from the plate and got deeper in the box. In 2024, Caminero was 26.6 inches deep in the box and 27.9 inches off the plate. In 2025, Caminero shifted 1.2 inches deeper in the box and .9 inches off the plate.

CAMINERO'S UNIQUE SWING PATH

Moving further from the plate, while a small distance and change when compared to the degree of his open stance, is an interesting change that plays well with his swing. Caminero has one of the flattest swings in MLB, but also displays some of the best bat speed. Caminero's swing averages around 10 degrees less tilt than the MLB average (32 degrees vs. Caminero's 25 degrees). With the MLB average at 71.7 MPH for bat speed, Caminero averages 79.6 MPH, placing him in the 100th percentile.

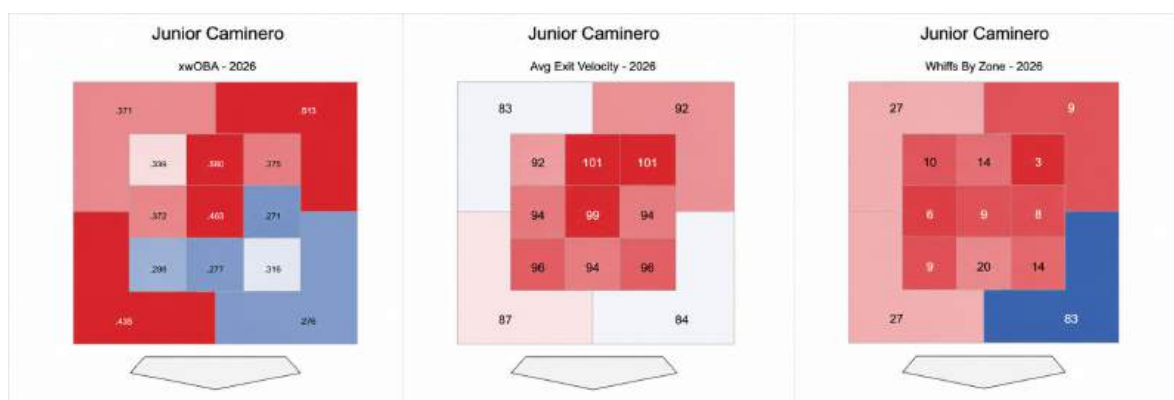


Figure 4. Caminero's 2026 xwOBA, exit velocity, and whiff rate by zone

Caminero has one the [fastest, flattest swings in baseball](#). Caminero's flat bat path allows him to barrel the baseball more, being in the 92nd percentile in hard hit and the 87th in barrel %, as he stays on plane with the ball better than a player with more of an uppercut swing. His flat bat path also gives him an advantage against today's pitchers' typical attack plans. Oftentimes, pitchers' game plans revolve around the high fastball getting above the barrel of the bat to force weak contact and whiffs. Again, this is more successful against players with uppercut swings. Caminero's swing gives him the unique ability to protect against the high fastball better than most players. Figure 4 shows that Caminero has been able to protect against whiffs at the top of the zone and to produce high exit velocities and batted-ball data. The flat swing does raise some concerns, specifically about higher GB% and offspeed down in the zone. With an average launch angle of 10.7 degrees in 2025 and 9.1 degrees in 2026 (MLB average 12.5 degrees), Caminero does occasionally fall susceptible to this. Nevertheless, Caminero has an outlier swing and has an outlier offensive profile.

A BAT FIRST SUPERSTAR

Caminero does not provide as much value defensively or on the basepaths (0 DRS, -14 OAA, -2.6 BsR), which places more pressure on his bat to carry his overall profile. However, Caminero's offensive production has already shown the potential to be a carrying tool for years, especially given the level of power he has displayed at such a young age. Caminero was the 19th-fastest player to reach 50 home runs in MLB history, at 22 years and 70 days, and is only 9 home runs away from becoming the 3rd youngest player in MLB history to reach 100 home runs, only behind Mel Ott and Tony Conigliaro. His bat drastically outweighs the limited defensive and baserunning value in his profile, and that level of offensive impact will be critical to his long-term ceiling.

James Wood

23.5 years old

Service Time: 1.091

G	AVG/OBP/SLG	HR	RBI	SB	BsR	wRC+	DRS	fWAR
120	.265/.391/.528	30	74	18	1.8	148	-7	3.9

COMBINING ELITE POWER WITH ELITE DISCIPLINE

Wood has been in the spotlight since the Juan Soto trade and has always been a prolific hitter, but like PCA and Caminero, made another jump this year. A common trend among players making breakthroughs is a change in their approach and improved swing decisions. Wood has increased in BB% from 12.3% to 16.7%, going from elite to top tier, almost doubling MLB's average, while decreasing his K% from 32.1% → 28.3%. While his K% is still high, Wood can offset that with his high BB%, but could still look to improve. wOBA/xwOBA: .353/.361 → .392/.416, showing ever more impressive underlying data. At 6'7, Wood is a massive human and has always shown plus EVs and the ability to hit the ball hard. It was interesting to see that his max EV is down this year (118.0 to 116.3). Still, his bat speed/fast-swing % saw jumps (76 mph → 76.9 mph, 62.7% → 69.2%), with his average EV increasing from 94.3 to 95.3. Looking deeper, Wood has turned into one of the most selective hitters in the league by seeing more pitches and taking walks (swing % down 40.2% → 37.9%, out of zone swing: 24.3% → 21.9%, in zone swing: 55.8% → 57.2%). Wood has been able to barrel more pitches this year, with a higher launch angle. Wood has aimed to lift the ball higher, increasing his FB% from 26.6% to 35.4%. Despite this, Wood is getting more consistent swing off and barreling the ball more often, and, combined with improved launch angles, has developed more power this season. Wood's blast contact% and blast swing% from 2025-2026 have increased from 22.7% to 25.1%, and 15.9% to 18.3%, respectively. There is a question of whether he is being *too* selective. PCA and Caminero are both in the 40s for their overall swing%, closer to the MLB average. The more concerning swing decision metric for Wood is that his z-swing% is 56.2%, 11.2% lower than the average. This is evidenced by his higher proportion of strikeouts looking. Of his strikeouts this year, 33.8% have been looking, 9.2% more than the MLB average.

AN IMPROVED ATTACK ANGLE TO INCREASED BATTED BALL CONTACT

The biggest changes Wood has made in 2026 to his swing compared to 2025 can be found by looking at his setup as the pitch approaches. In Figure 5, we see Wood has flattened out the angle of his barrel in his pre-pitch setup. In 2025 (left panel), Wood was slightly more crouched, with his hands close to his head, and the barrel of the bat directed at the edge of the right-handed batter's box. In 2026, Wood's barrel is flatter, possibly to offset his larger frame and higher hand setup. The flatter pre-pitch barrel may have simplified his bat path through the zone, contributing to his ability to barrel the baseball more consistently in 2026 rather than get under it. Wood has increased his sweet spot percentage from the 70th percentile in 2025 to the 87th in 2026, and is centering the ball on all pitch types more frequently (see Figure 6). This could also be why Wood has increased his average launch angle from 6.3 degrees in 2025 to 9.3 degrees in 2026, as centering the ball allows him to create more consistent line-drive and fly-ball power.



Figure 5. Wood's pre-pitch barrel and stance position, 2025 vs. 2026

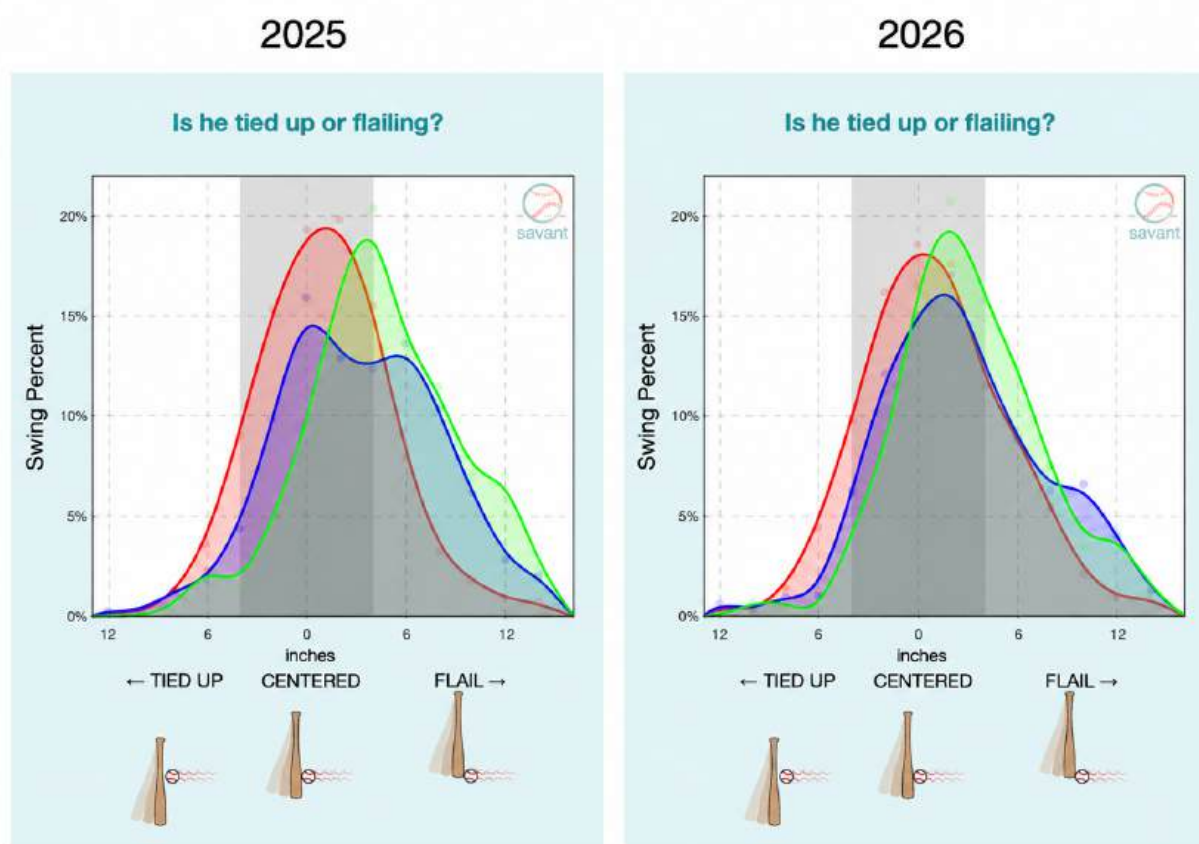


Figure 6. Wood's 2025 and 2026 bat-tracking contact distributions

STANCE AND PLATE POSITION CHANGES

Another factor that could be a cause for Wood's jump in 2026 is that he is standing closer to home plate. Wood is 2.6 inches closer to the plate in 2026, with his feet 2.8 inches closer together on his setup. Wood's opposite-field power is well known, and by moving closer to the plate, as shown in Figure 7, Wood may improve his ability to use his long arms to his advantage and cover the outer half better. Being able to get his barrel to pitches on the outer half allows him to take advantage of his unique opposite-field power, increasing his oppo% by 2.4% from 2025, along with sporting impressive xwOBA on pitches up and away (Figure 8).

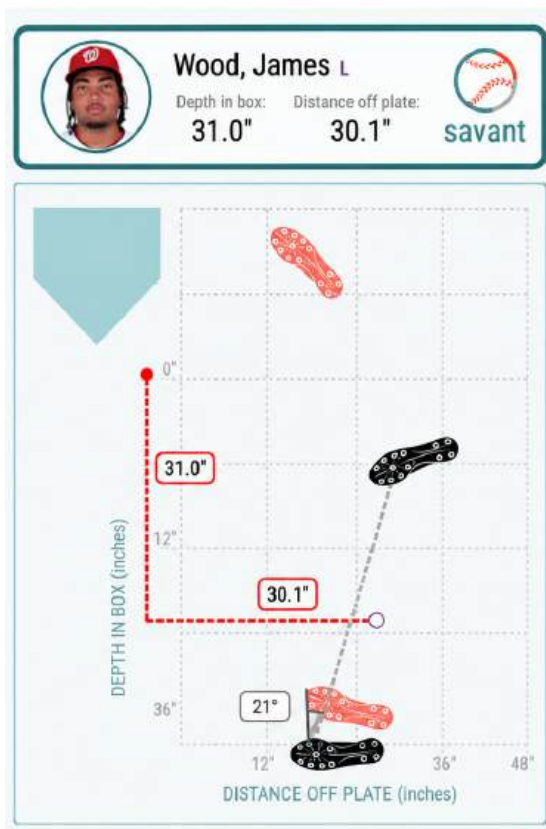
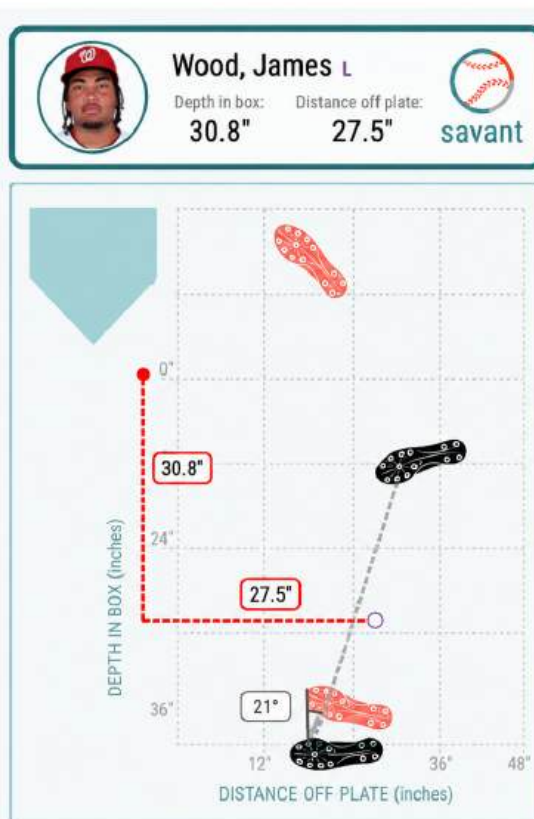
2025**2026**

Figure 7. Wood's batter's-box depth and distance from the plate, 2025 vs. 2026

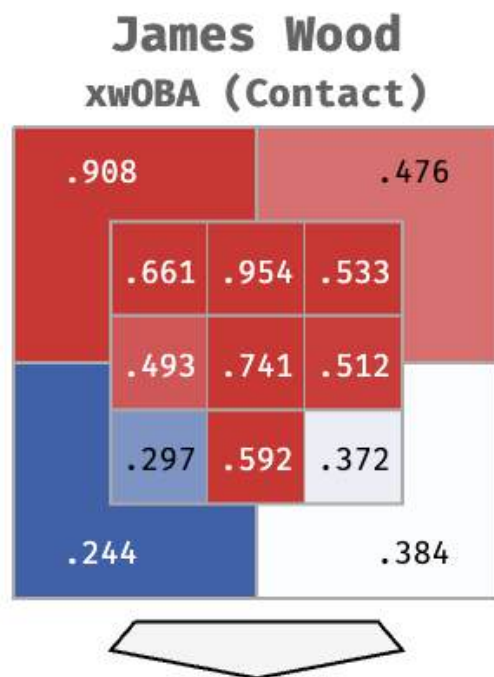


Figure 8. Wood's xwOBA on contact by strike-zone location

A UNIQUE POWER-SPEED COMBO WITH ROOM TO GROW

Wood provides value on the basepaths, using his long legs and strides to move efficiently. Wood has SB ability, snagging 18 bags so far, despite ranking in the 47th percentile in sprint speed. Wood does not profile well as an RF due to a below-average range and poor arm value, but his bat and speed on the basepaths make him a unique power-speed combo. Wood has considerably improved every year in nearly every offensive category and, before his oblique injury, was turning into one of the most complete power hitters in the league. To achieve this, he should continue reducing his K% and examine his underlying low z-swing%. Wood's power and ability to use all fields give him a high ceiling, but his production could continue to improve if he finds a balance between remaining patient in his approach and being too selective that he takes hittable strikes.

Jordan Walker

23.8 years old

Service Time: 2.044

G	AVG/OBP/SLG	HR	RBI	SB	BsR	wRC+	DRS	fWAR
142	.282/.338/.490	28	100	19	1.8	128	-6	3.0

A LATE BLOOMER BUILT ON INCREASING LIFT

Walker came into 2026 after a disappointing start to his career, but has been able to show true power potential to recapture the projection he had as a former top prospect. Between 2024 and 2025, Walker combined for -23.0 wRAA. So far in 2026, Walker has a 20.3 wRAA, completely transforming himself as a hitter. Unlike the previous players, Walker has not become more selective, with his BB% remaining relatively consistent (7.3% → 7.4%), and his swing% is actually up from 49.4% in 2025 to 52.3%. The main difference in his advanced stats is that Walker is barreling the ball more and leaning into his pull-side power. Walker's overall hard-hit% is down 1.4%, but he is finding the barrel at an even higher clip, going from 10.9% to 13.0%. Walker is also pulling the ball in the air more. His pull% is up 4.2% from 2025, his overall launch angle is up 1.8 degrees, and as a result, he has increased his HR/FB from 6.6% to 17.5%. He may have been due for some positive regression in this area, as 6.6% was unbelievably below average, with 17.7% just now 4.2% above MLB average. Walker has always had elite bat speed (99th percentile in 2025, 100th in 2026), and he is now combining his plus bat speed with his strong arms and lower half to lift the ball to left easily and more consistently in 2026.

REBUILDING THE SETUP AND SEEING THE BALL DEEPER



Figure 9. Walker's pre-pitch stance and hand position, 2025 vs. 2026

Walker made significant changes to both his batting stance and his pre-pitch load between 2025 and 2026. As shown in Figure 9, Walker previously had an open stance and a narrow start before incorporating a moderate leg lift. Walker also started with his hands closer to his head and had to load with a decent amount of movement before the pitch. The 2026 panel in Figure 9 shows Walker's hands placed further away from his head, lessening the need for the same size load that could have led to more swing inconsistencies. Similar to Wood, Walker's bat path is also flatter during his setup. Walker's large frame and long arms force him to be compact and short to the ball so as not to cast the barrel, but when combining that factor with the higher attack angle from his pre-pitch load, it may have contributed to Walker's low launch angle in 2025. In 2026, Walker reduced the size of his load, moved deeper in the box and further off the plate, closed his stance, and reduced the distance between his feet (Figure 10). Walker can see the pitch deeper towards the plate, and the results have followed, especially on offspeed pitches. In 2025, Walker was susceptible to flailing at offspeed pitches, causing him to be off time and on top of the baseball.

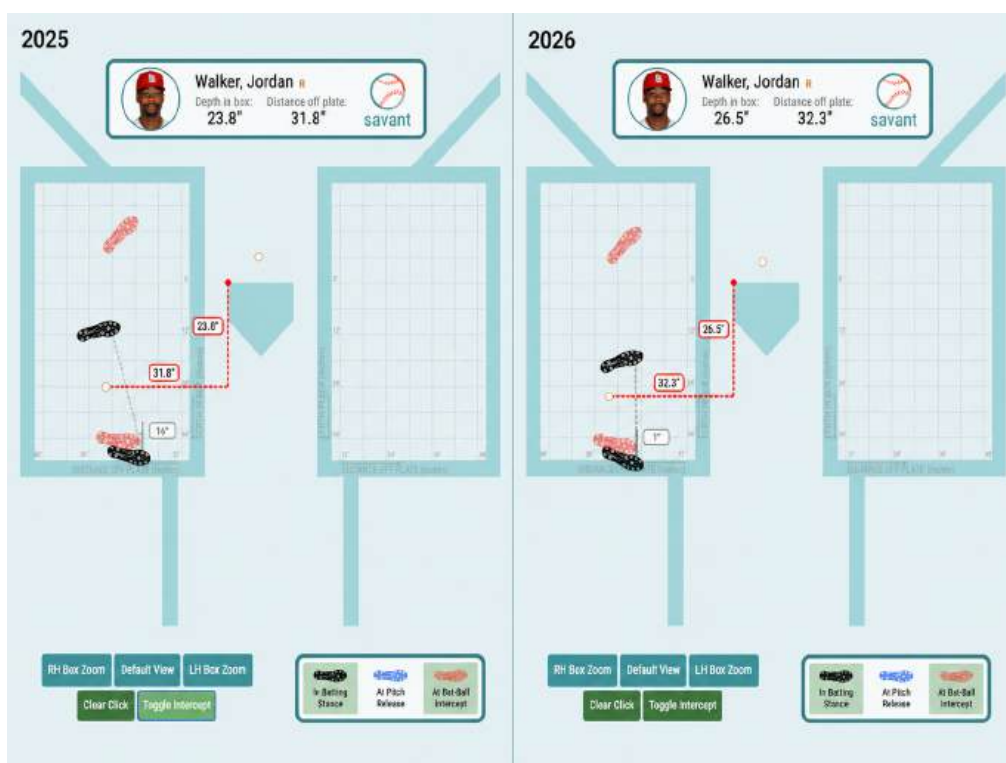
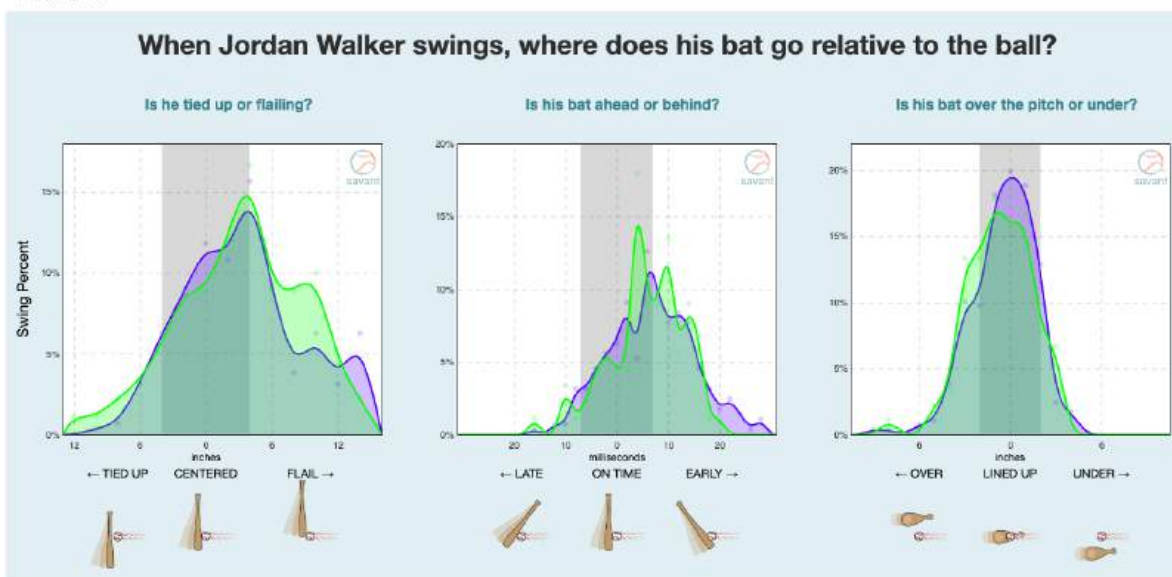


Figure 10. Walker's batter's-box depth and distance from the plate, 2025 vs. 2026

2025



2026

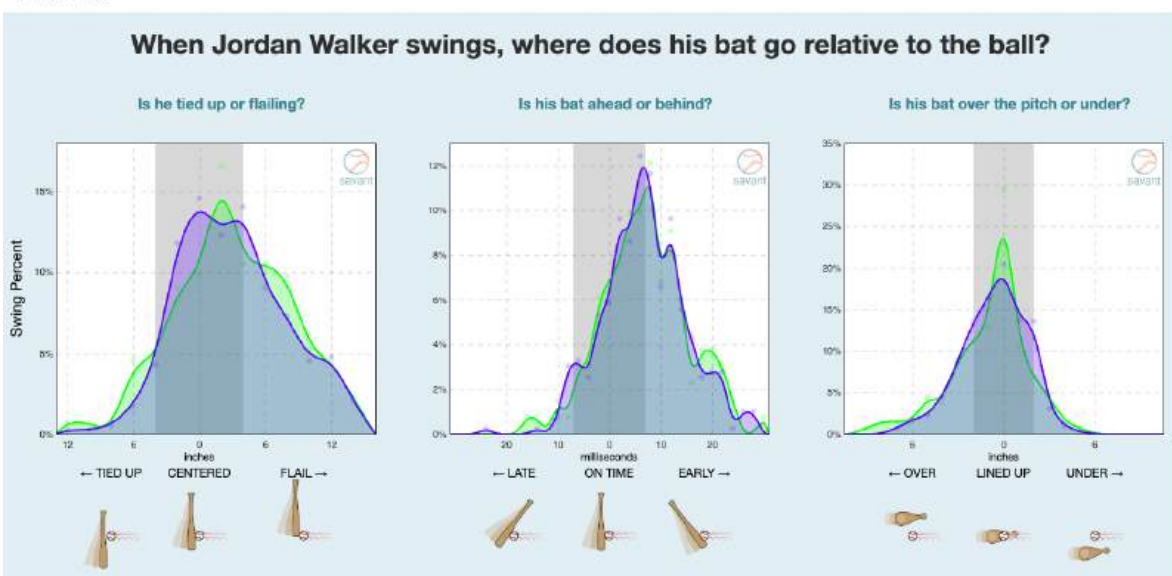


Figure 11. Walker's 2025 and 2026 bat-tracking contact and timing distributions

The swing changes and pre-pitch setup may have contributed to Walker seeing more offspeed and breaking pitches deeper in the zone, taking advantage of the leverage his long arms and compact swing provide. Seeing the pitch deeper and not flailing on pitches allows Walker to use his large frame to lift the ball more consistently and avoid leaking out on his front leg, which would reduce power and launch angle. In 2025, Walker saw 28.6% sliders and sweepers, and hit them for a combined run value of -7. On the 9.3% of changeups he saw, he had a -2 run value, and a whopping -6 run value of fastballs (24.5% seen). In 2026, Walker had almost identical pitch usage numbers on his pitches (23.9% fastballs, 29.3 slider/sweeper, 9.1% changeup), but

has increased his run value on three different movement profiles: a 10-run increase on slider/sweepers, an 8-run increase on changeups and fastballs.

ELITE ARM, LIMITED RANGE

Walker is another bat-first power hitter with limited defensive range in the outfield. However, as a right fielder, Walker profiles well due to his plus arm strength (99th percentile). Walker's lack of range will need to be covered in right field. We have seen teams take approaches to limit defensive holes in right. In Philadelphia, Nick Castellanos [started shifting towards the right-center gap more](#), because he was better going in and to his right. This gave him more of those chances that he was strong at. Walker has 2 OAA on balls he has to move back on, and -5 OAA/-4 OAA on balls where he has to move laterally to the left and right respectively. In his career, he has 1 OAA moving back on balls, and -13 moving towards 3B and 1B. Walker's limited range but strong arm could influence how the Cardinals construct and position their outfield in the future, especially if his continued power progression and arm strength outweigh his range limitations as the long-term option in RF.

Jac Caglianone

23.1 years old

Service Time: .118

G	AVG/OBP/SLG	HR	RBI	SB	BsR	wRC+	DRS	fWAR
131	.283/.331/.494	23	70	6	1.5	127	-4	2.4

COMBINING RAW POWER WITH BETTER BALL FLIGHT

Jac Caglianone was drafted as an exciting two-way prospect from Florida, showing great power potential and a clearer path to the majors with his bat. Caglianone got a taste of major league pitching in 2025, gathering 232 plate appearances. Caglianone struggled to the tune of a 47 wRC+ and a wOBA of .239. It was worth noting he was due for some positive regression, as his xwOBA was significantly higher at .321. In 2025, Caglianone has consistently shown plus exit velocities but has struggled to consistently barrel up and lift the ball to take advantage of his raw power. Caglianone had an average launch angle of 4.1 degrees, an average EV of 89.4 MPH, and a hard-hit% of 42.4%. In 2026, those metrics improved to 7.7 degrees, 93.1 MPH, and 54.4%, respectively. His wOBA currently sits at .356, almost identical to his xwOBA at .357. These improved results can be supported by the changes to Caglianone's GB%, FB%, and LD% rates. Caglianone has consistently started hitting line drives and fly balls more rather than hitting the ball into the ground. His GB% is down 3.2%, while his LD% is up 6.9%.

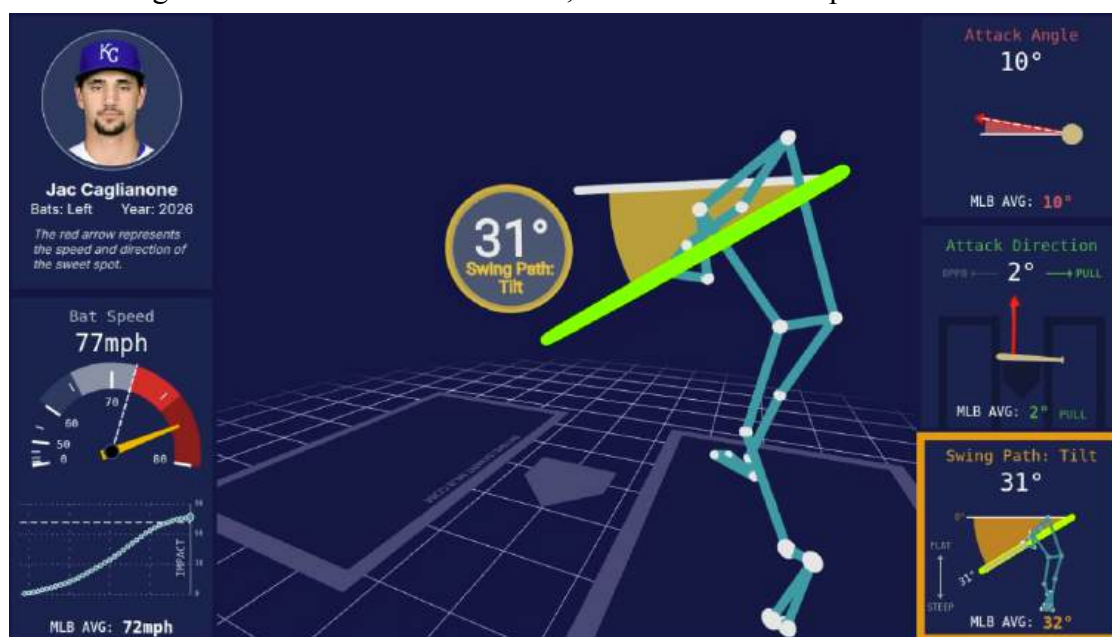


Figure 12. Caglianone's 2026 Baseball Savant bat-tracking profile

HUNTING PITCHES IN HIS ZONE

Unlike the previous players, Caglianone has not made any substantial changes to his batting stance or swing. With just a taste in the majors in 2025, it makes sense to get a full season of games under the belt before making any advanced mechanical adjustments. As previously mentioned, Caglianone is hitting more line drives despite his below-average launch angle. A reason for this could be his pitch selection in the zone. Compared to 2025, Caglianone's contact rates are down 2.0% overall (z-contact% and o-contact% down 5.8% and .2%, respectively). However, Caglianone's z-swing% is up 6.5%, from 65.3% to 71.8%. Figure 13 shows that the increase has come primarily from becoming more aggressive on strikes in the middle and upper portions of the zone. His swing% across the middle row rose from 54-69% to 74-79%, while the upper row increased from 68-76% to 72-79%. By contrast, his swing rate on pitches at the bottom of the strike zone remained relatively stable overall. Caglianone already attacked pitches in the zone at a higher clip than most, but in 2026 he has become more aggressive on hittable strikes without simply expanding his swing decisions. His strong batted-ball results and ability to produce high exit velocities on more pitches in the zone have benefited him immensely.

Caglianone has the more prototypical swing in MLB, with average tilt and attack angles (Figure 12). By hunting hittable pitches in the strike zone more frequently, Caglianone is giving himself more opportunities to make hard contact, consistent with his improved overall results. Caglianone has moved from the 46th percentile in hard-hit% in 2025 to the 98th percentile in 2026, with his average exit velocity increasing from 89.4 MPH to 93.1 MPH.

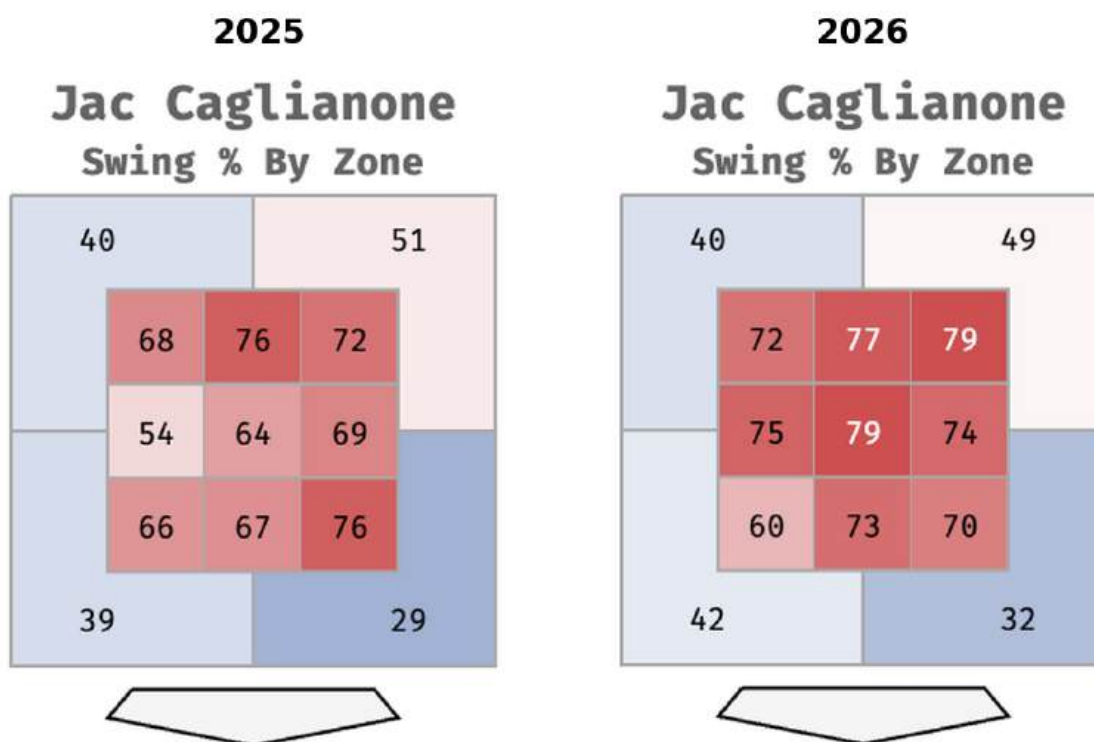


Figure 13. Caglianone's Swing% by zone, 2025 vs. 2026

THE NEXT STEPS

Caglianone is still a relatively raw prospect. Having only focused on hitting full-time after being drafted in 2024, there is considerable upside remaining in his offensive development. He is already producing at a high level despite a below-average launch angle, and the next step will be to determine whether he can generate more consistent lift without sacrificing the exit velocities that make his power profile unique. A below-average launch angle does not inherently prevent offensive success; Fernando Tatis Jr. has a 122 wRC+ despite a below-average launch angle (5.5 degrees). For Caglianone, it will be worth monitoring whether his current performance remains sustainable with his present LD% and FB% or whether further adjustments are needed to access his raw power more consistently. If he can maintain his high exit velocities while producing more optimal launch outcomes, Caglianone has the frame and natural power to develop into an impact left-handed power hitter.

Sal Stewart

22.3 years old

Service Time: .028

Prospect Promotion Incentive (PPI) Eligible

G	AVG/OBP/SLG	HR	RBI	SB	BsR	wRC+	DRS	fWAR
145	.264/.335/.477	31	107	15	-1.9	118	-5	2.5

HOW PITCHERS ADJUSTED TO STEWART'S HOT START

Similar to Caglianone, Stewart got a brief showing in 2025 and displayed why he was one of the most exciting young prospects for the Reds in recent memory. Stewart hit 5 HRs in only 18 games, giving the Reds an exciting bat to pair with Elly De la Cruz in 2026. Previously in 2025, Stewart was a clear power bat in MiLB— between AA and AAA, slugging .525 with 20 HRs in 118 games. So far, Stewart has been at the center of the NL Rookie of the Year Race. Stewart started scorching hot in 2026 before pitchers adjusted their game plans. May was the worst month for Stewart, accumulating a 95 wRC+ and a .337 xwOBA over that span, down from his 152 wRC+ start. Stewart himself said pitchers were starting to change their game plans against him to get his timing off, causing him to miss his pitches, especially the ones he had not missed in March and April. Looking at Stewart's Baseball Savant bat tracking and spray chart section, Stewart's strengths are to the pull side (not saying he doesn't show good power the other way as well). Stewart also shows good timing on fastballs with his swing, meaning he is hitting them and looking to do damage to the pull side. When the pitcher is off his timing, he is more susceptible to getting under the ball. Baseball Savant's chart shows that on fastballs, Stewart's bat path does tend to get under the fastball at a higher clip. Because his strength is in hunting fastballs and pitcher game plans threw off his timing, it is no surprise he went through an extended slump. In March and April, Stewart produced 19 barrels in 134 PAs, with a 44.6% hard-hit%. In 119 PAs in May, he had only 6 barrels, with a hard-hit% of 34.6%. He was less susceptible to slumps like this in MiLB, where the fastball shapes were less optimal than from ML pitching, missing and getting under bats or off the barrel more frequently. Stewart was seeing roughly the same percentage of 4-seam fastballs in May (.4% lower than March/April), but was seeing a higher percentage of cutters and curveballs. Stewart saw 2% more cutters and 3.1% more curveballs.

THE ADJUSTMENT: TIMING AND PITCH RECOGNITION

Pitchers were getting the ball off his barrel more often by throwing their cutters and playing their fastballs up in the zone, using the vertical break of the curveball to change eye

levels. Stewart's strength in power production is up in the zone, having advanced xwOBA and exit velocity on pitches up in the zone. However, as shown in Figure 14, Stewart is not squaring up the pitches up in the zone at the same rate as pitches down in the zone, showing Stewart will still miss those hittable pitches up in the zone. Continuing to adjust to more offspeed pitches to stay on those high fastballs may be crucial to continuing his success. Stewart has already shown this ability and, since June 1st, has produced a 113 wRC+ and a .798 OPS. While Stewart has improved his ability to get on time for fastballs, he still has a tendency to be late and get under the ball compared to offspeed pitches. Still, Stewart has vastly improved month over month this season, as he continues to gain confidence in his pitch tracking and timing. His xwOBA has gone from .318 in July to .355 in August. In the same span, as pitchers become more comfortable with offspeed pitches, they are being forced to throw more fastballs to Stewart (up to a season-high 26.5%), contributing to better outcomes.

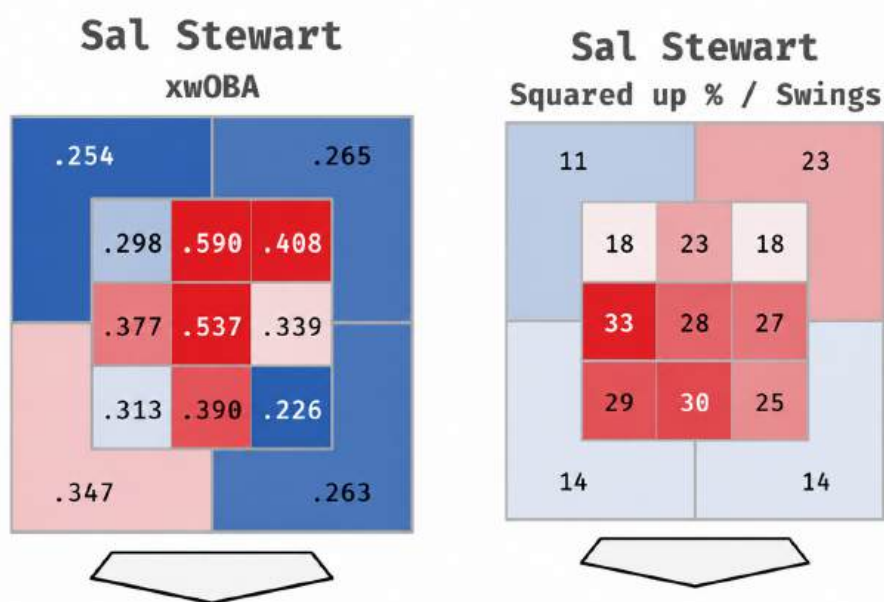


Figure 14. Stewart's xwOBA and squared-up rate per swing by zone.

SITUATIONAL SWING ADJUSTMENTS

The most impressive part of Stewart's game is the ability to display multiple swings and approaches based on the situation. Paule Hembekides first mentioned this on his ESPN podcast with Buster Olney, detailing how his splits are much improved in high-leverage situations and that he will take his swings and misses with the bases open. With RISP, Stewart is slashing .313/.376/.597 with a wRC+ of 149 and a BB% of 11.6% and a K% of 16.8%. With the bases empty, Stewart slashes .257/.336/.470, still good for a wRC+ of 120, but with a BB% of 9.5% and a K% of 24.1%. Stewart will chase and take more free swings to chase his power, increasing his chase rate by 3% with the bases empty. The biggest visual difference in Stewart's swing is his

follow-through. In this home run from May 20th, with a runner on first, no one out, and 2 strikes, Stewart takes an aggressive swing with a full follow-through. Compare that with his bases-clearing [double against the Yankees on June 20th](#), where there were bases loaded, 2 outs, and 2 strikes. Stewart shortens up, becoming more compact and direct to the ball, reducing the length of his swing to gain more barrel control in delivery. It is a subtle reduction in swing length, but important nevertheless. This is an extremely advanced skill set displayed by the 22-year-old, providing the Reds with a middle-of-the-order bat for years to come.

A BAT-FIRST PROFILE

Stewart's tools outside of his bat have received more scrutiny as he has been compared with JJ Wetherholt and Carson Benge in the Rookie of the Year race. He does not provide much defensive value and has been slightly below average at first base, although that is less concerning for a player whose long-term profile is likely centered around first base and DH. Stewart also ranks below average in sprint speed, but his 15 stolen bases and positive baserunning value show that he has still been able to create value on the bases despite the lack of pure speed.

More impressive than any individual tool has been Stewart's adaptability to different pitch mixes and game situations. His ability to deploy multiple approaches depending on the count and situation, while also making in-season adjustments as pitchers changed how they attacked him, points to an advanced level of baseball sense. That adaptability should remain one of the most important parts of his offensive development as he becomes more familiar with MLB pitching and continues facing new counter-adjustments.

Kevin McGonigle

21.6 years old
PPI Pick Eligible

G	AVG/OBP/SLG	HR	RBI	SB	BsR	wRC+	DRS	fWAR
140	.273/.373/.419	16	62	12	2.9	126	7	4.8

ADJUSTING TO THE FASTBALL

Kevin McGonigle displays one of the safest floors of the rookie class and can be a mainstay in All-Star lineups for years to come. Previously, McGonigle slashed .308/.410/.512 in his minor league career, which lasted 208 games. McGonigle was tabbed the #2 overall prospect in baseball during the 2025 season update on MLB Pipeline, so this is not the biggest surprise. McGonigle has displayed multiple tools this season but, like Stewart, also struggled in May as pitchers have adjusted. However, McGonigle has bounced back at a stronger rate than Stewart to become the frontrunner in the AL Rookie of the Year race. In May, McGonigle had a wRC+ of 90 and an xwOBA of .302, a steep drop-off from his meteoric start, where he produced a wRC+ of 166 with a .413 xwOBA. Similar to Stewart, the biggest adjustment McGonigle had to face was getting on time for the fastball. In March and April, McGonigle saw 24.8% fastballs in his plate appearances; that number rose to 31.8% in May and has remained at that level since. One of the reasons McGonigle's floor is so high offensively is his bat-to-ball skills and plate vision. While an adjustment period was necessary, McGonigle's ability to consistently put the bat on the ball could have helped him work through these pitch-plan adjustments. Figure 15 shows 2 traits: 1) it is tough to beat McGonigle, as he is more susceptible to flail and be early on breaking balls/offspeed pitches rather than be tied up or late, and 2) despite being off time, McGonigle consistently has his barrel lined up to the ball. This not only improves his ability to make contact but also allows him to foul off tough pitches and make the pitcher work to get to a better pitch he can drive. His plate vision is also evidenced by his strong BB%, which currently sits well above average at 13.5%. Even during his slump in May, McGonigle's vision stood out as he was still able to walk at a 13.6% clip, which is why he has probably the safest floor out of any rookie in a while. Even when McGonigle is not putting his best swing or barrel on the ball, his elite eye and bat control allow him to find ways on base and put up high-quality ABs.

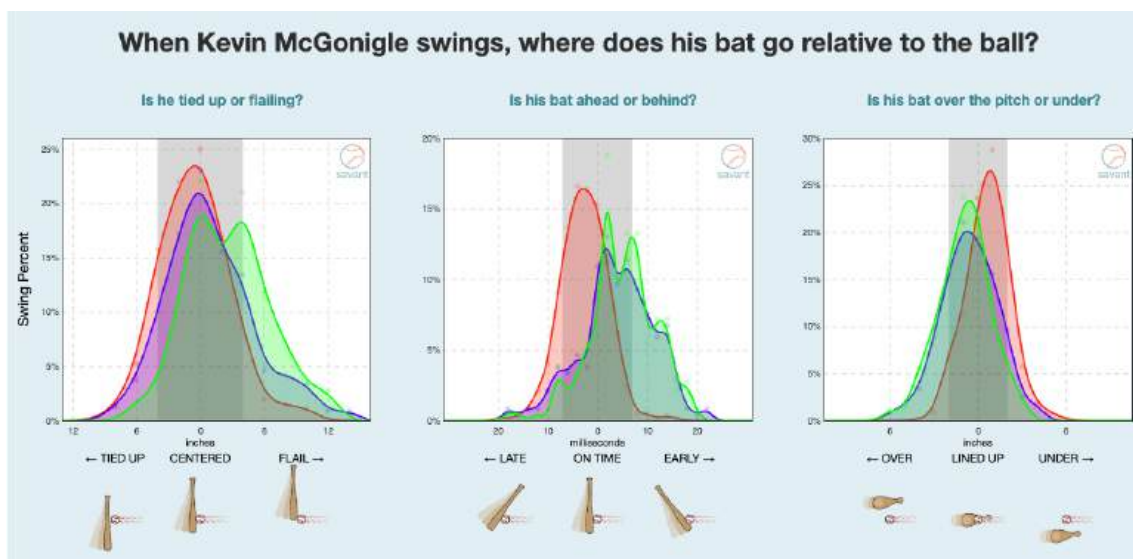


Figure 15. McGonigle's bat-tracking contact and timing distributions

ELITE VISION AND BAT CONTROL

McGonigle presents a profile different from the previous players discussed, focusing less on advanced batted-ball data and power production and relying more on his advanced eye. McGonigle has a hard hit% of 36.3%, slightly below the league average of 40%. McGonigle also lacks advanced bat speed, ranking in the 33rd percentile and showing a fast swing of 16.0%, which is 8.3% below average. However, McGonigle has a compact swing and can spray the ball all over the field thanks to his sound mechanics. McGonigle, at 5'9", starts from a smaller crouched stance with a wide base, 8 inches wider than the average MLB hitter. This provides McGonigle with good balance, which fuels his bat control.

WIDENING HIS BASE TO ADD POP TO HIS COMPACT SWING

Figure 16 compares McGonigle in high school in 2022 with this year. He has become more crouched and widened his stance over time to take advantage of his frame and to add more lift and launch angle to his profile (average launch angle is 20 degrees in 2026). The wider stance may allow him to sit more into his back leg during his swing, generating more power through his right arm, which punches directly through the bat's handle. In high school, his arms are more tied up close to his body due to his more upright stance and compact swing. The combination of greater balance through his legs and his natural bat-to-ball skills from his still-compact swing has contributed to McGonigle driving the baseball to all fields.



Figure 16. McGonigle's swing and lower-half positioning, 2022 vs. 2026

McGonigle uses his height, stance, and compact swing to have good control over the strike zone, reducing his whiffs while also barreling the baseball consistently. McGonigle currently sits in the 88th percentile for whiff rate, while sporting a 13.5% BB% against a 13.5% K%, elite in both categories. Figures 17 and 18 reinforce that strength: McGonigle limits whiffs across nearly every area of the strike zone while still showing the ability to handle 95+ mph velocity at the top of the zone.

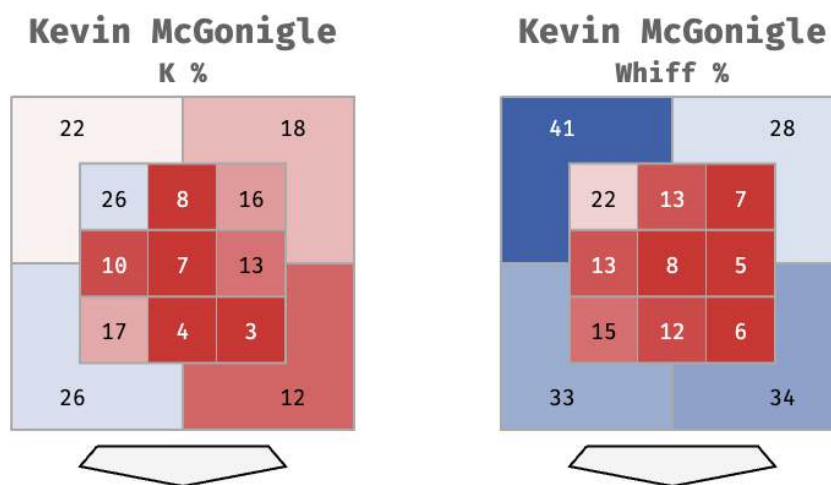


Figure 17. McGonigle's strikeout and whiff rates by zone



Figure 18. Location of 95+ mph pitches faced by McGonigle

HIGH FLOOR AND SAFE PLAYER PROFILE

McGonigle's defensive ability also adds to his floor because, despite not being an above-average athlete in the field, his baseball sense and instincts allow him to provide value across multiple positions for the Tigers. McGonigle has 8 total DRS, with 6 coming at third base and 1 at shortstop. He provides Detroit with a reliable glove on the left side of the infield while also giving the organization long-term flexibility as it evaluates the eventual promotion of MLB Pipeline's No. 48 prospect Bryce Rainer (ETA 2028).

OAA is less favorable toward McGonigle defensively, grading him at -1 OAA overall, with more issues moving laterally toward first base (-2 OAA) and is 5 OAA worse against left-handed hitters. However, McGonigle has shown that he can offset some of those range limitations with sure hands and strong defensive instincts.

Because of his already high floor, the larger question for McGonigle is how much power he will ultimately be able to tap into. His wide base, strong bat-to-ball skills and ability to lift the ball, combined with the fact that he is only 21 and still has room to mature physically, provide reason to believe there could be additional game power in his profile.

Carson Benge

23.2 years old
PPI Pick Eligible

G	AVG/OBP/SLG	HR	RBI	SB	BsR	wRC+	DRS	fWAR
139	.274/.335/.413	16	54	22	3.9	109	3	3.1

THE TURNING POINT

Carson Benge is a prime example of how in-season mechanical changes can increase a rookie's offensive value. We will dive deeper into those specific changes in the next section and will look at the stats and metrics that have specifically changed for Benge first. Benge, similar to Caglianone, was a two-way college player with a quicker path to the majors because of his bat. Unlike Stewart and McGonigle, Benge did not come out of the gates strong; instead, May was the month the turnaround began for Benge. In March and April, Benge was getting his feet under him against major league pitching, feeling his swing out, and struggling, to the tune of a 48 wRC+ and a xwOBA of .286. Benge made a noticeable swing change heading into May, and the results followed. From May 1st onward, Benge slashed .291/.353/.440 with a 122 wRC+ and a xwOBA of .345.

OPTIMIZING HIS COMPACT SWING AND USING THE OPPOSITE FIELD

Benge made noticeable changes to his batting stance around May 1st, and the underlying data shows that his new stance and swing mechanics have aligned with an increase in his attack angle and more consistent barreling up of the baseball. Benge's swing was leveling out early in the year, and for March and April, Benge was only able to swing at the ideal attack angle (between 5 and 20 degrees) 37.3% of the time. This likely played a role in a lower barrel% and a lower launch angle; Benge's barrel percentage was 4.5%, with an average launch angle of 9.5 degrees. His new stance and swing created a better attack angle on Benge's swing (Figure 19), now with above-average tilt that allows him to swing at the ideal attack angle 4.9% more often, while also barreling the ball 3.0% more than March and April at an average launch angle of 12.3 degrees. Benge is lifting the ball more and has optimized his bat path to produce more consistent hard contact with the barrel. There is also evidence that Benge is adjusting to offspeed pitching better, sitting back more on using the opposite field. Benge uses the opposite field about 10% more often than the MLB average, at 27.6%. This is clearly a strength for Benge – [this home run off a Michael King sinker](#) was an impressive display of opposite-field power – and leaning into this will only help Benge moving forward.

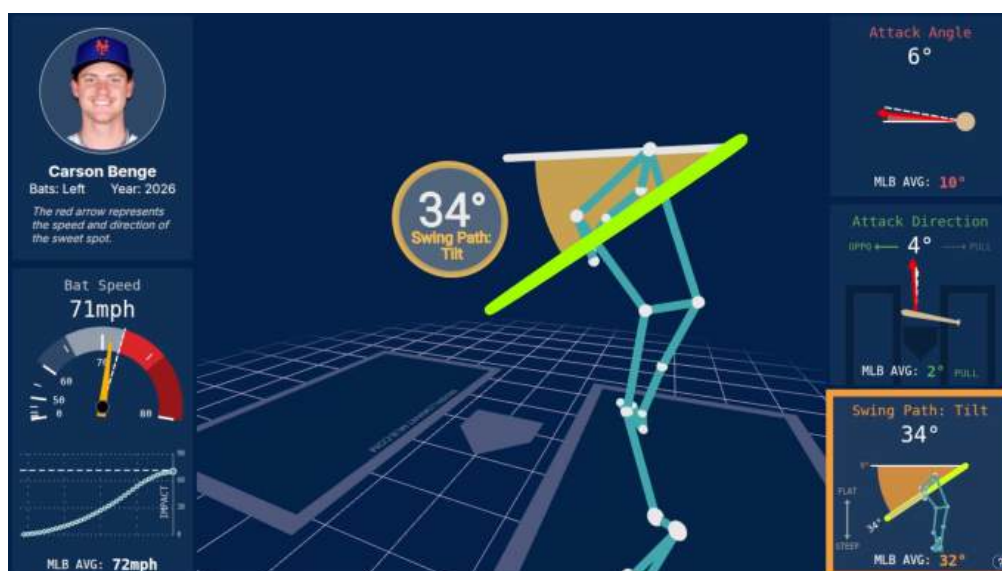


Figure 19. Benge's 2026 Baseball Savant bat-tracking profile

STANCE AND SETUP CHANGES

Jared Greenspan detailed Benge's stance changes in Figure 20. Over the course of the year, Benge closed his stance while also resting his bat on his shoulder, possibly to relax his hands during his pre-pitch setup (Figure 20). These were pretty significant in-season changes, changing his stance to be 21 degrees more closed and backing off the plate more (Figure 21). Being more closed off could be helping Benge with his opposite-field power. Being closed could allow Benge to be able to fire his hips a bit earlier before the barrel comes through the zone, given the nature of his short, compact swing. Benge's swing is 7 inches shorter than MLB average, but he is taking advantage of it by staying closed longer and hitting the ball further out in front of the plate.



Figure 20. Benge's pre-pitch stance progression, March 28–August 17, 2026

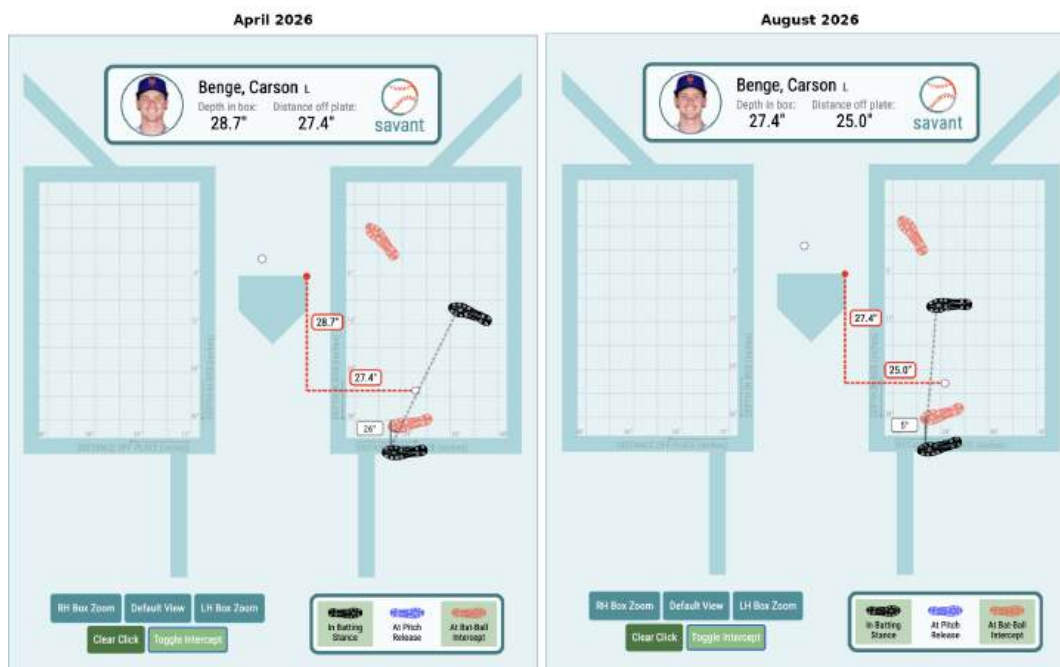


Figure 21. Benge's batter's-box depth and distance from the plate, April 2026 vs. August 2026.

ELITE ARM AND OVERALL UPSIDE

Benge is an above-average athlete with the tools to become an above-average defender in right field, thanks to his average range and elite arm. Benge possesses a strong arm from his days pitching at Oklahoma State and ranks in the 100th percentile in arm value and the 99th percentile for arm strength. Benge has already made several notable assists from right field this year, with [this throw to nab Bryan Rocchio](#), who was attempting to go from first to third, being one of the most impressive. The play showed Benge's ability to work around the baseball, create momentum toward the bag, quickly flip his hips and deliver a strong throw. His ability to collect himself, get his feet underneath him and efficiently transfer that momentum into the throw stood out. Benge still shows some qualities from his pitching background, including an impressive front-leg block when throwing. This [throw against the Padres to get Jake Cronenworth at home plate](#) is another example of Benge getting his body behind the baseball and aligning his hips with the target before quickly delivering a strong one-hop throw. Benge also shows good sprint speed and above-average baserunning instincts, adding 3.9 baserunning runs and 22 stolen bases this season.

Benge's in-season stance adjustment and ability to adapt to Major League pitching have raised his offensive ceiling, while his athleticism, arm strength and baserunning give him multiple ways to provide value. The next test will be whether those offensive improvements are sustainable as pitchers continue to adjust. At the same time, additional progress in his reads and routes could allow his elite arm to play even more consistently in right field.

JJ Wetherholt

23.5 years old
PPI Pick Eligible

G	AVG/OBP/SLG	HR	RBI	SB	BsR	wRC+	DRS	fWAR
130	.242/.343/.370	17	48	14	3.4	104	12	4.4

SECOND-HALF DECLINE

JJ Wetherholt is currently leading the NL rookies in fWAR due to his strong offensive value at 2B and outstanding defensive ability. Wetherholt flew through AA and AAA in 2025, slashing .306/.421/.510 and making the Cardinals' opening-day roster in 2026, immediately jumpstarting their rebuild and being a good pair with Jordan Walker at the top of the Cardinals lineup. Unlike the previous rookies, Wetherholt did not face the May slump but has instead fallen off more in July and August. This may be more a result of fatigue, as the data supports his swing slightly breaking down as the season moves into the later stages. From March to June (77 games), Wetherholt slashed .261/.358/.405, producing a 116 wRC+ with a .349 xwOBA, adding 12 home runs while playing Gold Glove defense at second base. Since the start of July, in 52 games, Wetherholt has slashed to .211/.320/.317 and slumped to an 85 wRC+. A silver lining for Wetherholt is that his xwOBA has risen to .353, suggesting he may be due for some positive regression given his strong batted-ball results.

FATIGUE, WRIST TENDONITIS AND FALLING BAT SPEED

The biggest change in Wetherholt's data is that his swing appears to tire over the course of the season. The most games Wetherholt has played before this year is 109, in 2025, in AA and AAA. Wetherholt, in his first 77 games, has a max EV of 108.7 mph and an average launch angle of 13.9 degrees. In the next 48 games, Wetherholt's max velo has dropped to 105.5 mph, while his average launch angle has significantly decreased to 8.4 degrees. His bat-tracking metrics also indicate a potentially fatigued bat, with Wetherholt's Fast-Swing% (the percentage of swings that reach 75 mph) falling from 22.8% to 14.5%. Combine this with a shift in his attack direction from -4 degrees to -10 degrees, meaning his barrel could be slowing a bit more in the zone and traveling more toward the opposite field at contact. This could be consistent with Wetherholt getting the barrel around later than he was earlier in the season.

This could imply that the direction of Wetherholt's barrel is lagging as a result of his falling bat speed. While it is good just to list numbers, this falling bat speed may have contributed to Wetherholt losing some of his strengths on the field, especially his pullside air power— Wetherholt is pulling the ball 4.8% less of the time, while also increasing his GB% from 40.8% to 50.9%. Despite losing some thump in his bat later in the season, Wetherholt's plate

vision and discipline have remained consistent. Wetherholt is in the 95th percentile for chase rates and has maintained a BB% of 10.9% throughout the season, and has even improved to a 16.5% BB% since July 1st.

NOTE: When this report was initially started, Wetherholt was not placed on the IL for right wrist tendonitis. That is his bottom hand that drives the knob to the ball and controls the barrel of the bat, while also playing a role in the follow-through, especially in keeping the wrists from rolling over. I was curious to see if Wetherholt was fatiguing during his first full season, but now I wonder whether he had been playing through the injury or trying to for some time, which may have contributed to his offensive downturn. Nevertheless, my analysis still stands, and with his plate discipline staying consistent, Wetherholt should focus on recovery and continue to grow stamina and strength as a player in 2027 and beyond to build on a very successful rookie campaign.

QUIET, SOUND MECHANICS AND ADVANCED ZONE CONTROL

Wetherholt provides a unique profile compared to the rest of these players, as his glove is his best tool. However, Wetherholt still combines a sound mechanical swing with elite plate discipline, profiling as an above-average bat. The biggest change in Wetherholt's stance came this offseason, as Figure 22 compares his minor league stance in 2025 to his stance on Opening Day. Wetherholt is more upright at the plate with a less rigid base, mainly due to narrowing his feet. His hands are lower and closer to his body, with a slight bat movement as he waits for the pitcher to set. These combinations could suggest Wetherholt is looking to be more fluid and loose in his swing, finding more rhythm and staying relaxed.



Figure 22. Wetherholt's 2025 MiLB stance and 2026 Opening Day stance

When looking at his actual swing, he displays a smooth rhythm with a moderate leg kick before finishing closed with his stride towards SS. The relaxed nature of his pre-pitch setup

allows his fluid swing and clean mechanics to build off each other, making a continuous natural swing very evident for the 2024 first-round pick. He does tend to leak out on his front side, especially on pitches away. Figure 23 shows an extreme drop-off on pitches away in his wOBA, even relative to the other cold zones up and in, with a .189 down and away and a .218 middle away.

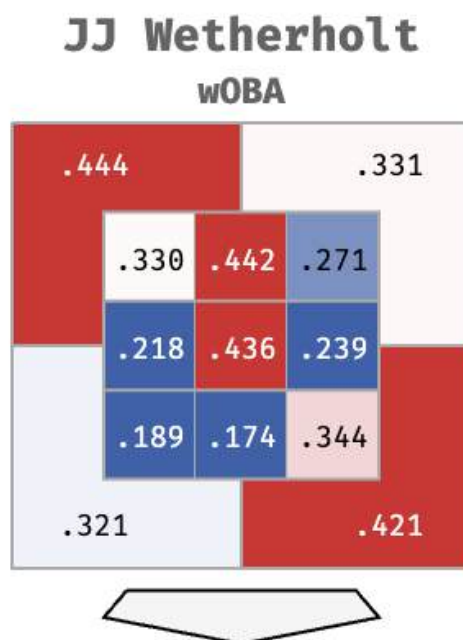


Figure 23. Wetherholt's wOBA by strike-zone location

As the pitch approaches, Wetherholt displays very simple mechanics, with little extra movement and overall a very quiet swing. This allows Wetherholt to barrel the baseball more consistently, especially when you combine that with his elite vision and plate discipline, which he is at the 95th percentile in chase rate. This could help explain Wetherholt's ability to limit the size of his misses on the baseball, as he is well above average at avoiding breaking pitches and making consistent, on-time contact with the meat of the baseball. This has led Wetherholt to currently sit at the 88th percentile for squared-up rate.

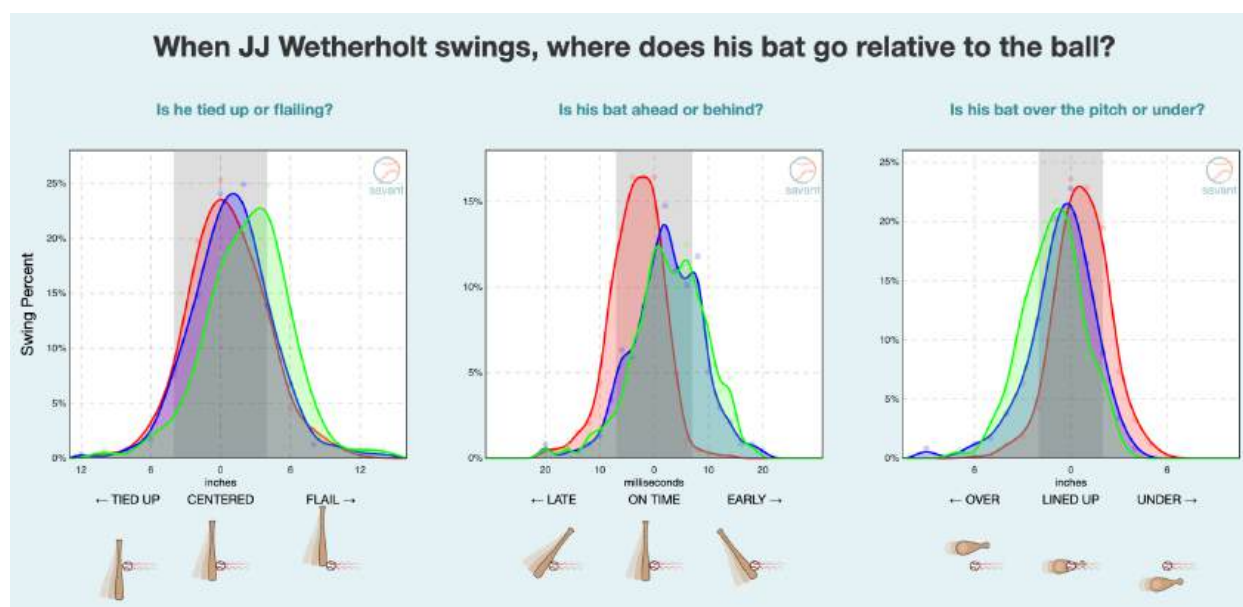


Figure 24. Wetherholt's bat-tracking contact and timing distributions

Pitch	Avg. Miss Dist. (Inches)	Flawed Swing %	Perfect Contact %
Fastball	0.9	3%	31%
Breaking	3.3	5%	29%
Offspeed	2.1	8%	22%

Figure 25. Wetherholt's miss distance, flawed-swing rate and perfect-contact rate by pitch type

GOLD GLOVE POTENTIAL AND 20/20 UPSIDE

Wetherholt has already established himself as one of the most impactful defensive second basemen in baseball during his rookie season, with the major defensive value and range metrics supporting his case. With 12 DRS and 22 OAA, few second basemen cover as much ground as Wetherholt. Baseball Savant ranks him in the 100th percentile for range, and he has been particularly effective moving laterally toward third base, producing 12 OAA on plays in that direction. While Wetherholt does not have the strongest arm, ranking in the 19th percentile, that limitation is less significant given his range and defensive position at second base. Even with moderate speed, Wetherholt also provides value on the basepaths, stealing 14 bases while producing 3.4 BsR in 2026.

At this point, we do not yet know how much of Wetherholt's second-half decline was due to normal rookie fatigue, the wrist injury, or a more exploitable offensive weakness. A larger healthy sample should help distinguish between those factors, making his offensive response one of the more interesting developments to monitor in 2027.

Chase DeLauter

24.5 years old
PPI Pick Eligible

G	AVG/OBP/SLG	HR	RBI	SB	BsR	wRC+	DRS	fWAR
120	.294/.365/.458	13	60	10	0.1	133	1	3.1

EARLY PRODUCTION AND MIDSEASON TURNAROUND

Chase DeLauter has some similarities in terms of development pattern in 2026 to some of the previous rookies, but has been hit with the injury bug more than the others (as I write this on 08/24, DeLauter was scratched against the Angels due to hamstring tightness). DeLauter got off to a great start in March and April, slashing .257/.345/.485 with a 132 wRC+ and a .373 xwOBA. Similar to Stewart and McGonigle, DeLauter's production slowed in May before he landed in the IL with a rib cage contusion on June 17. From May 1st to June 17th, DeLauter had a wRC+ of 96 and an xwOBA of .321. DeLauter returned from injury producing at an even higher level. Since returning from injury on June 28th, DeLauter is slashing .332/.397/.517, accounting for a 158 wRC+ and an xwOBA of .342. It is worth noting his wOBA is .397, so the difference may indicate DeLauter is due for some regression towards the end of the season.

Nevertheless, DeLauter has hit at a very high level, with strong production over extended stretches at this point in his young career. The biggest difference maker for DeLauter moving forward is his approach at the plate. When DeLauter is more disciplined and zones in on his pitches, he provides much more impactful swings. From May 1st to June 17th, DeLauter was more aggressive at the plate— DeLauter saw his out-of-zone contact % increase from 65.3% to 73.1%, while his called strike percentage decreased from 16.6% to 15.1%, which is already below MLB average. DeLauter has strong contact skills, with an 86.0% contact%, well above the MLB average of 75.2%, but needs to keep his approach refined to make the most of his bat-to-ball skills. Especially when you consider the fact that DeLauter slugs extremely well against breaking balls. In 2026, DeLauter is slugging .471 against breaking balls with a wOBA of .362. He would not be sacrificing any power because of this, as he would see more pitches per at-bat and be more selective about his pitches.

THE SCISSOR KICK AND ZONE SPECIFIC SWING CHANGES

Looking at DeLauter's mechanics gives us a clear picture of what his pitch is and what he should be hunting for in an at-bat. DeLauter, at 6'3, stays more crouched in his setup and keeps his hands tight to his body as he swings. One of the defining features in his swing is his back leg scissor-kicking back. His swing also seems to pull him off the plate slightly towards the 1st base

dugout. This [clutch homer in the top of the 10th against the](#) Mariners on March 26, shown in the top-right panel of Figure 26, is a good example of how he uses his swing to his advantage, making him extremely hitterish by creating more space for his bat path on pitches on the inner half. The bottom right panel shows his setup, the bottom left panel shows his 1-2 take on a good backfoot slider from All-Star closer Andres Munoz, and the top right panel shows the contact point where he hit the next pitch, a 96.6 MPH fastball up, away, and out of the strike zone the other way for a go-ahead bomb. Not only does this at-bat show an extremely well-balanced approach but also demonstrates the scissor kick mentioned in his swing. On both pitches, the 1-2 take and the home run, DeLauter kicked the back leg back. The top left panel shows a home run from April 3rd against the Cubs, where he turned on an up-and-in fastball for a home run. Even in a different location, we see DeLauter use his scissor kick to get his hands through the baseball and lift it over the wall.



Figure 26. DeLauter swing examples showing his setup, two-strike take, and fastball home runs

Looking at his zone breakdowns and his swing metrics, we see this backed up by his strong xwOBA in pitches on the inner half, which aligns with his bat path. DeLauter can fire his hands and alter his swing depending on the location of the pitch to induce better results. We see DeLauter have a slightly below-average tilt in his overall swing numbers (Figure 27), but breaking it down by zone tells a different story. On pitches up and in, DeLauter shortens his swing by nearly a foot compared to down and in. Similar to the discussion with Caminero, DeLauter's flatter bat path (4 degrees) allows him to barrel these pitches more consistently, which is especially important given how pitchers use velocity up in the zone in today's game. When he sees pitches down and in, which often are offspeed pitches (think slider/sweepers from

righties, sinkers from lefties), DeLauter deploys a longer swing, but with above-average tilt, to get more backspin on the ball to the pull side.

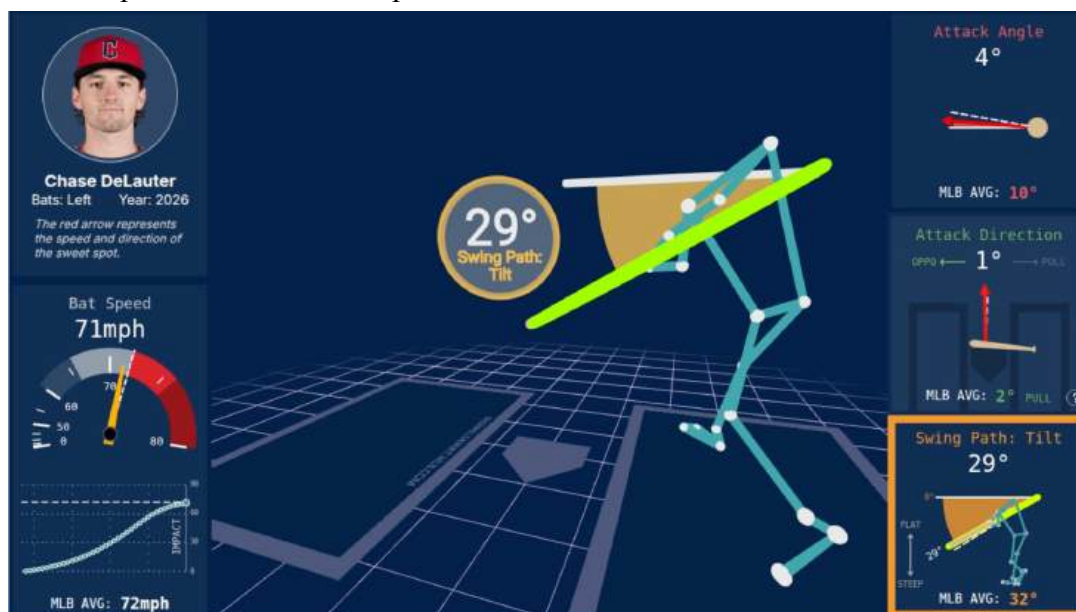


Figure 27. DeLauter's 2026 Baseball Savant bat-tracking profile

ZONE STRENGTHS AND WEAKNESSES

Figure 28 shows that DeLauter has the highest xwOBA across the 6 zones of the inner half, which aligns with his differences in swing length and swing path. His zone xwOBA also displays the potential holes in his swing, with drop-offs on pitches away in all 3 vertical quadrants. Other players on this list have made adjustments to their setup in the box to better reach pitches in the zone and cover all areas of the plate. With DeLauter's ability to shorten his swing on pitches in the zone, he could look to get closer to the plate to better protect against away pitches that currently give him issues.

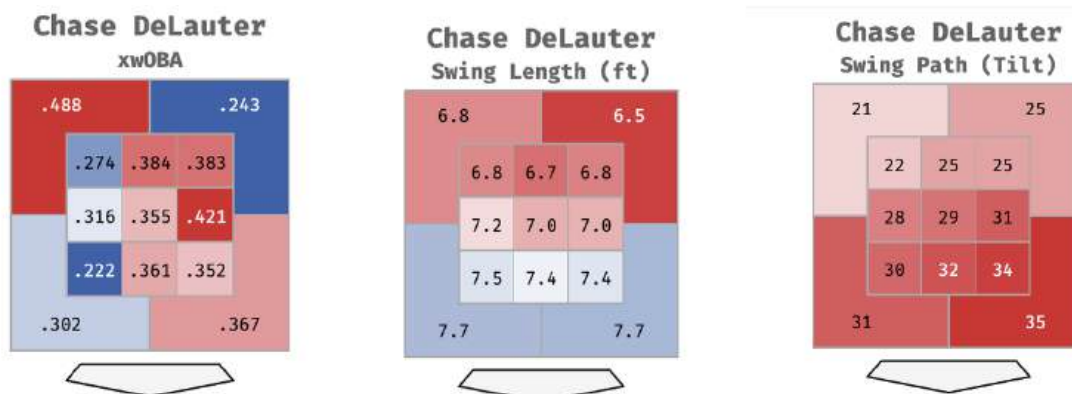


Figure 28. DeLauter's xwOBA, swing length and swing-path tilt by zone

A BAT FIRST CORNER BAT

DeLauter is a bat-first prospect, but he has displayed slightly above-average defensive ability in right field. While not the best athlete, DeLauter has accumulated 1 DRS and 1 FRV this season, with 1 OAA in right field. He does not currently profile as a strong long-term center-field option, recording -1 OAA in his career in limited opportunities there, making a corner-outfield role the more likely defensive fit. His offensive upside allows him to develop into a power-first corner bat for the Guardians. The biggest developmental question will be how he adjusts to the holes pitchers may target, particularly on the outer half of the zone, where his different swing shapes and results have shown greater vulnerability.

CONCLUSION

ADAPTABILITY AND PATIENCE

Looking at what these ten players have in common, there are fewer mechanical and swing similarities, but more similarities in their ability to adapt on the fly. This highlights how adaptability influences player development and league trends, making it a factor for scouts and analysts to consider.

Player	Peak Preseason MLB Pipeline Rank	Year
Kevin McGonigle	No. 2	2026
Junior Caminero	No. 4	2024
Jordan Walker	No. 4	2023
JJ Wetherholt	No. 5	2026
James Wood	No. 14	2024
Pete Crow-Armstrong	No. 16	2024
Carson Benge	No. 16	2026
Jac Caglianone	No. 22	2025
Sal Stewart	No. 22	2026
Chase DeLauter	No. 31	2024

Table 1. Peak preseason MLB Pipeline rankings for the 10 players in this report

Table 1 shows that each of these players was a highly rated prospect, with all securely in the top 35 at their peak in preseason MLB Pipeline rankings. Despite being the best-touted and highly projected players, each has gone through valleys that have led to their peaks. Each of the rookies had noted extended slumps during 2026 before bouncing back and adjusting. [PCA had a 131 wRC+ in the first half of 2025 before cratering to a 72 wRC+ in the second half](#). Jordan Walker spent multiple stints in the minor leagues after his 117 wRC+ rookie year. Caglianone's rookie year was a throwaway year for a middling Royals team; Wood was striking out 32% of the time in 2025. The only exception is Caminero, who boasted a 105 wRC+ in his first extended run of 40 games in 2024, another reason why I believe he will end up as one of this generation's most prolific power hitters.

It would be easy to say that what allowed these players to get out of their slumps was simply their approach or standing closer to the plate, but each of these players showed that there is no single true way to improve. A defining factor is rather the ability to read the game in front of you and adapt your individual game to better the team. Hitting a baseball is the hardest thing

in sports, and the age of data and velocity in baseball has made pitchers harder to hit than ever. Yes, some of these players made similar adjustments—PCA, Caminero, and Wood have all gotten more selective and increased their BB%. But Bengie, Walker, and Caglianone have higher K% and lower BB% relative to the group. Wood, Walker, McGonigle, and Caglianone have focused on lifting the ball more and increasing their launch angle, but Caminero, Wetherholt, Bengie, and DeLauter succeed with below-average launch angles.

One takeaway for MLB organizations from this ten-player pool is to trust the talent of their top prospects, allow time to adjust to each level of MiLB and eventually MLB, and look for holes in their approach first to optimize results before tearing down their swing. Often, prospect rankings evaluate talent, age, and production relative to the MiLB level. There is no universal way to make significant jumps in a player's game. The beauty of baseball is each player has a truly unique skill set, and it's an organization's job to optimize their performance based on the skill set. In MiLB, the raw talent of these top prospects allows them to succeed more often than not. However, in baseball, failure is inevitable, and allowing these prospects to continue refining their raw talent and developing their baseball IQ through playing experience will enable maximum growth. Too often, prospects fizzle out because of high expectations for success, especially if they achieve early success or receive quick promotions in their careers.

Ethan Salas is a good example of this. Salas had a quick rise after signing for \$5.6 million as a 16-year-old, before advancing to AA at 17. Salas flew up prospect rankings, ranking as high as number 8 in the 2024 preseason MLB Pipeline rankings. After his 2025 season, Salas was unranked on MLB Pipeline's list due to offensive struggles and a stress reaction in his back. Salas has since returned to form, earning a promotion to AAA in 2026, slashing .326/.410/.539, good for a 128 wRC+, and was recently called up to the Padres for their 2026 playoff push at just 20 years old. Salas had huge expectations, but needed time to adjust to the game in front of him. Salas displayed advanced defensive tools, but the Padres allowed his bat to develop and now provide them a strong cornerstone at the valuable catcher position for years to come.

PLAYER DEVELOPMENT TAKEAWAYS

I talk about patience and managing expectations to allow prospects to develop, given the recent MLB owners' proposal to reduce the pool of eligible players for the MLB Amateur Draft to college underclassmen, thereby eliminating the advanced high school prospects from entering organizations sooner. The biggest difference between College Baseball and MiLB lies in their focus. College baseball incentivizes winning, with playing time given to the most productive performers, sometimes at the expense of development. MiLB, on the other hand, prioritizes providing players with opportunities to succeed and fail and fostering growth throughout the minor leagues.

College Baseball coaches, with 50-60 games per year, have a shorter leash on playing time and focus on performance over training and growth. College coaching staff may bench or reduce the roles of players who struggle early in the year. This may not always provide a positive environment for player development; prospects need to experience both success and failure in

their seasons and have a sense of comfort or trust that the organization is behind them and will support them through any struggles. We see organizations build trust with players through periods of struggle, and that trust pays off in time. Jordan Walker is the best example of that, as some were ready to give up on him and he was even projected to begin 2026 in AAA because of his lack of offensive production in a crowded Cardinals outfield. St. Louis' willingness to continue investing time and resources in Walker through his repeated struggles helped preserve a breakout star in their system, who became a vital contributor in 2026.

Because College Baseball places greater emphasis on year-in, year-out results, we also see shorter leashes for players and fewer pitch-count restrictions. In the 2023 Super Regionals, Quinn Mathews of Stanford threw a CG with 16 strikeouts, but it took him 156 pitches. It was an all-time performance, but it shows the focus of college baseball. Quinn Mathews was drafted 1 month after he threw and is currently in the Cardinals system, but his 156-pitch outing before the draft shows the Stanford coaching staff were playing for 1 game, not necessarily for the next years of Matthews' career. Did Matthews want to come out or regret it? Probably not. Is it bad for a player, team, or program to want to win and have that competitive edge? Absolutely not. But as an MLB organization, getting players in my player development system to monitor workload and control their progression plans would prevent overuse issues driven by a focus on winning. This is not to say college baseball is bad at developing players, as access to information and [advanced training programs](#) has spread across many D1 programs. There is simply a different incentive structure in place that doesn't always provide the most optimal development program. These 10-player cases raise questions about what could be lost if responsibility for development shifts substantially away from MLB organizations.

IMPACT ON MLB AND THE UPCOMING CBA NEGOTIATIONS

I also wanted to draw some broader conclusions about what these players' breakouts could mean for the greater game of baseball. There is recent evidence suggesting owners may be incentivized to outsource their minor league development systems to college baseball to cut costs for their organizations. The owners' CBA proposals during the Amateur Draft reduced the total rounds from 20 to 12 and the bonus pool from \$358.7M to \$200M, indicating they are not looking to expand investment in the amateur draft. This is an extreme proposal that may not gain much traction on the MLBPA side during the offseason negotiations. The proposal could be a response to the growing trend discussed in the league's preface: getting younger.

Player	Age at Signing	Years	Contract	Pre-MLB Path	MLB Draft Position
Juan Soto	26	15	\$765M	Dominican Republic	International FA
Shohei Ohtani	29	10	\$700M	Hokkaido Nippon-Ham Fighters	NPB Posting
Vladimir Guerrero Jr.	26	14	\$500M	Dominican Republic	International FA
Mike Trout	27	12	\$426.5M	Millville Senior High School (NJ)	Round 1, Pick 25
Mookie Betts	27	12	\$365M	John Overton High School (TN)	Round 5, Pick 172
Aaron Judge	30	9	\$360M	Fresno State	Round 1, Pick 32
Manny Machado	30	11	\$350M	Brito Miami Private School (FL)	Round 1, Pick 3
Francisco Lindor	27	10	\$341M	Montverde Academy (FL)	Round 1, Pick 8
Fernando Tatis Jr.	22	14	\$340M	Dominican Republic	International FA
Bryce Harper	26	13	\$330M	College of Southern Nevada (JUCO)	Round 1, Pick 1
Corey Seager	27	10	\$325M	Northwest Cabarrus High School (NC)	Round 1, Pick 18
Giancarlo Stanton	25	13	\$325M	Notre Dame High School (CA)	Round 2, Pick 76
Yoshinobu Yamamoto	25	12	\$325M	Orix Buffaloes	NPB Posting
Gerrit Cole	29	9	\$324M	UCLA	Round 1, Pick 1
Rafael Devers	26	10	\$313.5M	Dominican Republic	International FA

Table 2. The 15 largest MLB contracts by guaranteed value, with age, length, and development path.

The interesting question is not whether one development path produces better players, but whether entering professional baseball earlier can affect the timeline for when elite players reach arbitration and free agency. As the league gets younger, so does the age at which players enter free agency, often tied more closely to their prime years of 26-29. Table 2 shows the 15 largest contracts handed out in MLB history; 13 of the players did not go to a D1 college, with 6 being drafted out of high school, 1 going to JUCO (Bryce Harper), 4 being international signings, and 2 coming from the NPB, with only Aaron Judge and Gerrit Cole attending college. If you expand the cutoff to the top 30 largest contracts by total money, only 6 collegiate players are added to the

list, with David Price, Anthony Rendon, Trea Turner, and Stephen Strasburg attending D1 schools, and Albert Pujols attending a JUCO program. The average age at signing of those 30 contract players is 27.97 years, with a length of 10.17 contract years, for an average of \$327.56 million. Of those 30 contracts, players who went to college signed 2.05 years later than high school draftees (27.62 years for high school draftees, 29.67 for D1 college drafted), signed deals about 1.5 years shorter (9.85 years for HS, 8.33 for college), and made \$19.65 million less in total money (\$293.48 million for high school, \$273.83 million for college). While there is no direct correlation between high school players and total career earnings, it may be a factor owners consider in CBA negotiations.

Some of the most exciting young players in the game today (Max Clark, Konnor Griffin, Bryce Eldridge, Bobby Witt and more) did not go to college because their talent was elite enough that MLB organizations wanted them to develop under their guidance at a younger age and make an impact on their Major League club as soon as possible. While no direct data proves that high school/pro development is better than college development, it does show that different development paths can influence professional timelines, which matters when evaluating CBA proposals that could shift more development toward college baseball. Delaying players with these talents from entering the league when they are ready could decrease the overall quality of the game and unfairly punish them by preventing them from entering free agency at a younger age, thereby reducing their earning potential.

FINAL THOUGHTS

MLB is overflowing with young talent, and these ten players show how elite tools can put a prospect firmly on an organization's radar. What separates them is their adaptability, which determines how many of their five tools survive MLB competition. Their development within their respective organizations reinforces the idea that talent creates upside, but adaptability determines how much of that upside is realized. With players like this continuing to reach the Major Leagues at younger and younger ages, baseball's next generation of players is well-positioned to advance the game regardless of how the 2027 CBA negotiations reshape the game's landscape.

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Player statistical pages and tracking data were accessed from August 24, 2026, to September 9, 2026. Contract and player-development-path data were accessed from September 3-6, 2026.